Social Distortion Returns With Its First Album in 15 Years

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Mike Ness wants you to know one thing about the new Social Distortion album: it did not take 15 years to record. It may be the longest gap between albums in the Orange County **punk rock** band's history, but it was not for lack of trying.

Personal challenges, **relentless** touring, and ultimately a cancer **diagnosis** all delayed the record. Now, with Ness healthy and the band in fine form, Social Distortion has released its eighth **studio album**, "Born to Kill." The band joined the radio show World Cafe to perform songs from the new album.

On World Cafe, Ness talked in general terms about his tonsil cancer experience, without graphic detail, and what the long road meant to him. He also praised singer Lucinda Williams, who joins him for the **duet** "Crazy Dreamer."

Ness has spent his career writing about personal struggles, and he is starting to embrace more political themes in his songwriting. The episode simply notes this direction, without taking a side in a debate. The World Cafe episode featuring the band was released on October 23, 2026.

Word Treasure

punk rock -- A loud, fast kind of rock music.
duet -- A song sung by two people together.
diagnosis -- When a doctor finds out what illness a person has.
relentless -- Something that keeps going without stopping or resting.
studio album -- A collection of songs a band records in a studio to release together.

Background you need

Social Distortion is a punk rock band, a group that plays loud, fast rock music.

A studio album is a collection of songs a band records to release together.

The band had a long gap between albums because of personal challenges, lots of touring, and a cancer diagnosis for its singer.

Break it down

WHO: Mike Ness and the band Social Distortion, with singer Lucinda Williams joining for a duet.
WHAT: The band released its eighth studio album, Born to Kill, and performed songs from it on the radio show World Cafe.
WHERE: On the radio show World Cafe.
WHY: Ness is healthy again and the band is in fine form after a long gap caused by personal challenges, relentless touring, and a cancer diagnosis.

Why it matters

It shows you can return to something you love after a hard time, even if it takes a long while.

Test what you remember

1. What is the name of Social Distortion's new album?

- (A) World Cafe
- (B) Born to Kill
- (C) Social Distortion
- (D) Crazy Dreamer

2. Which studio album number is Born to Kill for the band?

- (A) Seventh
- (B) Ninth
- (C) Eighth
- (D) Fifth

3. What delayed the new record?

- (A) A broken guitar
- (B) A move to Venice
- (C) A change of singer
- (D) Personal challenges, relentless touring, and a cancer diagnosis

4. Who joins Mike Ness for the duet Crazy Dreamer?

- (A) Archie Renaux
- (B) Leslie Bibb
- (C) Lucinda Williams
- (D) Camila Mendes

5. On which radio show did the band perform songs from the new album?

- (A) London Live
- (B) Venice FM
- (C) Basel Radio
- (D) World Cafe

6. What kind of themes is Ness starting to embrace in his songwriting?

- (A) Songs about tennis
- (B) More political themes
- (C) Songs about movies
- (D) Only love songs

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: D 4: C 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):